

Past Winner Pattern Analysis (3–5 historical examples)

IBM hackathon winners (Call for Code, TechXchange watsonx events, SkillsBuild showcases, Bob/Granite-focused agentic AI hackathons 2024–2025) consistently reward **deep, multi-component IBM stack integration** (watsonx.ai, Granite models, Langflow-style orchestration, agentic/RAG systems, Guardian for safety) on projects with **measurable real-world social or humanitarian impact**. Presentations blend **story-driven hero narratives** (problem → solution → lives changed) with **technical demos** showing innovation and feasibility. Cinematic/fan-engagement flair appears in sports-adjacent wins; pure technical depth wins in enterprise-focused ones. Social-impact/accessibility framings **win repeatedly** via Call for Code precedent and SkillsBuild.

- **Team RescueRiser / FloodZap (Hackathon for Progress / Call for Code 2025, Kenya student team)**: watsonx.ai RAG + real-time data for flood alerts and personalized rescue plans (text-based for low-connectivity users). Won on climate/social impact + technical execution; coordinated with Red Cross. Wow factor: Lives saved in vulnerable communities.
- **Team Daimyo (TechXchange 2024 watsonx Hackathon, Indian student team)**: watsonx.ai + Granite app for restaurant data automation/efficiency. Post-win deal development; showcased deep stack use and business value.
- **Team Young & Hungry (AI Agent Hackathon / Call for Code clean water theme)**: watsonx-powered AI virtual agent for water/sanitation issues. Advanced to global judging on social good + IBM tech fidelity.
- **T-Chai / similar equitable-access winners (Call for Code 2024)**: Granite/watsonx solutions for education, essentials access, or productivity (e.g., brainstorming agents, disaster robots in SkillsBuild). Pattern: Student-led, open-source potential, governance/responsible AI elements.
- **SkillsBuild Impact Showcase prototypes (2025–2026, e.g., healthcare/agriculture/education AI, disaster-response robots)**: watsonx/Langflow/Granite builds focused on practical inclusion and skilling.

Historical data 2025–2026 tells IBM judges reward: Technical execution + innovation + challenge fit + **real-world/social impact** (exact Grand Prize criteria). They love agentic AI that scales like enterprise tools (Ferrari precedent), student portfolio projects using the full stack (Bob as accelerator), and accessibility/inclusion stories that align with IBM values. Shallow integration or pure tech demos without impact lose.

IBM's Top 5 Current Narratives + How PIT WALL Hooks Each

1. **IBM × Scuderia Ferrari (watsonx-powered AI Companion in app for ~400M fans, Bob for coding acceleration, Race Centre insights)**: PIT WALL directly mirrors this — same Granite + watsonx + Bob stack applied to racers/coaches instead of just fans.
Hook sentence: “PIT WALL extends the exact IBM watsonx + Bob stack powering

Scuderia Ferrari's fan engagement app to deliver post-race AI coaching for disabled, veteran, and grassroots drivers."

2. **IBM × Mission 44 (Lewis Hamilton's foundation + SkillsBuild for F1-themed AI/STEM skills, inclusivity in motorsport, 2025 multi-year partnership):** Perfect thematic and platform alignment for the May F1-inspired challenge. **Hook sentence:** "Building on IBM's Mission 44 partnership, PIT WALL delivers F1-level AI coaching via SkillsBuild to the very drivers Lewis Hamilton's foundation seeks to empower — disabled, veteran, and grassroots racers."
3. **IBM × Inclusive Brains (2025 joint study on multimodal AI/quantum/neurotech for adaptive brain-machine interfaces and accessibility/autonomy) + IBM 1914 accessibility heritage:** Direct fit for disabled racer tooling. **Hook sentence:** "PIT WALL advances IBM's 1914 legacy of workforce inclusion and its 2025 Inclusive Brains collaboration by using multimodal Granite Vision + TimeSeries models to close the adaptive-racing coaching gap for disabled athletes."
4. **watsonx.governance (responsible, transparent, explainable AI with Guardian models across regulated/high-stakes environments):** Safety-critical racing decisions demand this. **Hook sentence:** "PIT WALL embeds Granite Guardian 4.1 and watsonx.governance from day one to deliver bias-free, auditable, safety-critical post-race recommendations for high-stakes adaptive motorsport."
5. **IBM Granite open-source ecosystem (Apache 2.0 models — Docling, Vision 4.1, TimeSeries TTM, 8B Instruct/Guardian; ecosystem for enterprise + community innovation):** PIT WALL is built on it and can contribute back. **Hook sentence:** "Entirely powered by open-source IBM Granite models and Langflow, PIT WALL contributes a production-ready agentic racing engineer back to the Granite ecosystem, accelerating community innovation in motorsport accessibility."

Judging Panel Composition + Per-Judge Pitch Hooks

Judges are primarily **IBM internal** (SkillsBuild education leads, TechXchange dev/CSR teams like impact officers and bloggers, AI product experts) + **BeMyApp organizers** (platform operators). Possible F1/motorsport or SkillsBuild alumni guests for the May challenge. No heavy external motorsport partners evident in similar events.

- **IBM SkillsBuild / education judges:** Pattern-match on student skilling, portfolio-ready projects, and real-world applicability. Turn-offs: Academic-only demos. **Hardest hook:** The Billy Monger → Team BRIT / Mission Motorsport gap closed with SkillsBuild + Granite tools ("This is exactly the AI skilling outcome IBM built SkillsBuild for").
- **TechXchange / dev judges:** Pattern-match on deep IBM stack fidelity, agentic AI, Bob/Langflow use, technical wow. Turn-offs: Vague integrations. **Hardest hook:** Full-stack architecture ("Same Granite + Bob + watsonx stack IBM uses internally and with Ferrari — built by sophomores in a hackathon").
- **CSR / impact / Inclusive Brains-aligned judges:** Pattern-match on accessibility, social good, measurable inclusion. Turn-offs: Generic "AI for good." **Hardest hook:** Hero narrative + disabled/veteran/grassroots focus ("Extending IBM's 1914 inclusion heritage to the track for drivers left behind by FIA rules").

- **BeMyApp / general judges:** Pattern-match on clear presentation, innovation, challenge fit (F1 theme). **Hardest hook:** Cinematic hero story + live demo of post-race agentic insights.

"IBM Would Showcase This" Verdict

Yes — PIT WALL is an ideal IBM showcase project. It sits at the intersection of:

- **AI for social good** (Call for Code/Newsroom precedent: disaster response, equitable access, inclusion).
- **Granite open-source ecosystem** (student contributions to community models).
- **Bob built this app** narrative (agentic acceleration precedent in Ferrari app and internal dev).
- **Enterprise governance** (watsonx.governance + Guardian in safety-critical use case).

IBM features exactly this profile at TechXchange, SkillsBuild Impact Showcases, and newsroom: student teams using full Granite/watsonx stack on accessibility/motorsport/social-impact problems with strong demos and open-source potential. It will be positioned as “SkillsBuild student innovation meets Ferrari-level AI meets Mission 44 inclusion.”

Grand Prize Strategy (single submission vs. both)

Submit a single, exceptionally strong May (F1-themed) entry as the Grand Prize bid. The May challenge is explicitly “inspired by F1 car racing” — PIT WALL is native to it (post-race engineer for Team BRIT / Mission Motorsport / FFSA Handikart). Grand Prize criteria (technical execution, innovation, challenge fit, real-world impact) align perfectly. Precedent from multi-event Call for Code shows top entries from qualifying rounds advance on strength alone; a standout May project can carry the \$5,000 Grand across both without diluting focus.

June (FIFA) extension would feel forced for a racing team (possible soccer adaptive-coaching agent using same Granite stack for post-match analysis, but weaker narrative fit). Focus all energy on May to dominate the F1 theme and Grand Prize judging.

Post-Hackathon Trajectory Options

Strongest path: IBM-first leverage. Win → immediate IBM recognition/showcase at TechXchange/SkillsBuild events → **IBM Consulting recruitment/internship** (they hire top SkillsBuild hackathon talent for AI delivery roles). Secondary: IBM Ventures visibility or sports-tech acceleration (IBM-affiliated Web Summit programs). Open-source the core agent on Hugging Face via Granite ecosystem for community traction.

Pitch close should signal “enterprise-ready partnership trajectory”: “We are not just building a hackathon prototype — we are ready to scale PIT WALL with IBM Consulting into Team BRIT, Mission Motorsport, and beyond, while contributing back to Granite and SkillsBuild curricula.”

5 Specific Deck Sentences PIT WALL is Missing

- **watsonx.governance hook:** “PIT WALL incorporates Granite Guardian 4.1 and watsonx.governance from the ground up, delivering auditable, bias-mitigated, safety-critical AI recommendations that meet the highest enterprise standards for high-stakes adaptive racing.”
- **Mission 44 hook:** “In direct alignment with IBM’s Mission 44 partnership, PIT WALL brings F1-inspired AI coaching — powered by SkillsBuild — to disabled, veteran, and grassroots racers, advancing Lewis Hamilton’s mission of inclusive STEM opportunity in motorsport.”
- **TechXchange hook:** “Built for the IBM TechXchange stage, PIT WALL showcases the full enterprise Granite + watsonx + Bob stack in a production-ready agentic system — the same technologies powering Scuderia Ferrari’s fan experiences.”
- **Bob as build accelerator hook:** “From ideation to polished agentic engineer in weeks, IBM Bob served as our AI coding partner — proving how any student team can ship high-quality, governed AI applications at Ferrari-level velocity.”
- **Grand Prize trajectory hook:** “Positioned as the clear Grand Prize winner across both challenges, PIT WALL not only delivers immediate impact for adaptive racers but opens the door to IBM Consulting collaboration, Granite ecosystem contributions, and scaled deployment through Mission Motorsport and beyond.”

The Single Highest-Leverage Strategic Edit to the Pitch

Lead the entire deck with the Billy Monger 2017 → FIA rule change → “still no AI tooling” gap, then immediately bridge it to “the exact same IBM Granite + watsonx + Bob stack that powers Scuderia Ferrari’s 400M-fan app and Mission 44’s SkillsBuild initiatives.”

Make the hero narrative the opening 30-second hook, followed by a one-slide “IBM Stack in Action” architecture that visually maps every component (Granite-Docling → Vision → TimeSeries → Instruct → Guardian + Langflow + Bob) to racer outcomes. This single edit triggers every IBM judge reward pathway simultaneously: social impact + accessibility + deep tech + F1 narrative + governance + skills-building + showcase potential. It turns a good accessibility project into the undeniable “this is what IBM wants to feature” winner.